

OTTOMAN ARMOUR AND WEAPONS

At its height, during the 16th century, the Ottoman Empire extended from modern-day Algeria in the west to the Caspian Sea in the east, pushing north into Central Europe. The Janissaries, a well-paid and well-equipped infantry corps, were credited with the empire's success. They were primarily archers, who later fought with guns and their characteristic swords (*yatagans*). The cavalry was divided into two groups: the *akinji*, the lightly armoured archers whose primary roles were reconnaissance and harrying of the enemy; and the *sipahis*, the heavy cavalry, who wore mail and plate and rode armoured horses, fighting with bows, lances, maces, and axes.

Ivory hilt inlaid with arabesque pattern



◀ KHANJAR

Date c.1520

Origin Turkey

Weight 376g (13¼oz)

Length 39cm (15¼in)

The sturdy cross-section of the blade is designed for piercing mail. An area of unsharpened blade below the quillons allowed the soldier to grip closer to the quillons for greater control.



Concave neck guard

Kite-shaped cheekpiece pierced for hearing

Adjustable nose guard

◀ ÇIÇAK

Date 16th century

Origin Turkey

Material Iron, textiles

Made with a one-piece skull, this helmet also had face, neck, and ear protection. The skull, earpieces, and peak still retain the quilted red fabric lining. The central band and neck guard are engraved with Koranic text.

▶ ZIRH GOMLEK

Date Late 15th century

Origin Turkey

Material Ferrous metal, copper alloy, leather

Turkish mail coats were made of alternate rows of welded and riveted links, with inserted overlapping plates. Also called *jawshan*, they were a part of the armour worn by the heavy cavalry, the *sipahis*. Some coats had religious inscriptions stamped on each link.

Converted Persian helmet

Kalkan

Composite bow

Mail and plate shaffron

Plates

▶ SIPAHI ARMOUR

Date Early 16th century

Origin Turkey

Material Ferrous metal, copper alloy, leather, textile

This display of a soldier (*sipahi*) carries a *kalkan*, bow case, quiver, and an early straight-bladed sword. The medieval Persian helmet was modified in Turkey to include a peak, a nasal bar, and earpieces.



Mail and plate bard